

KiuFunza (“Thirst to Learn”)

Supporting Young Learners in African Primary Schools

A Twaweza East Africa Initiative

*More than 100 million children in Sub-Saharan Africa are in primary school but cannot read. **KiuFunza is a proven program** that has boosted young Tanzanian students’ literacy skills from 36 to 50 percent (and numeracy skills from 42 to 55 percent), at a cost of 7 USD per student – which makes it one of the most cost-effective programs in the world. KiuFunza enhances teacher agency and focus by providing early grade teachers with small cash incentives that are conditional on the learning outcomes of students in their classroom.*

Why KiuFunza? Sixty percent of 10-year-olds in Tanzania cannot read and comprehend a short story. The figure rises to 89 percent in Sub-Saharan Africa. This means that tens of millions of young students suffer from “learning poverty”, as a result of which they will struggle to complete primary school, transition to secondary, and complete their education career successfully.

The high rate of learning poverty in Sub-Saharan Africa violates the trust that students, families, and taxpayers put in the education system – trust that has led to near universal primary enrolment. It is unacceptable that despite all the time and resources invested in education across the continent, so few children are reading with comprehension at even a minimally adequate level; and so many fail to achieve the high lifetime returns that quality education can deliver, including positive effects on individual earnings, health, financial behavior, and social mobility.

KiuFunza targets grades 1, 2 and 3 in public primary schools because these early grades are crucial for Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN). Most teachers self-report they do not want to teach in these grades, because of the very large class sizes (often 100 students in a class). As Teacher Anna from the Dodoma region told us, “*We are like a spare part – nobody cares about us. Not the government or the communities we work in.*” Surprise visits have surfaced high classroom absenteeism, and a majority of local government officials confirm the problems of low teacher morale. This may explain why the modestly sized KiuFunza incentive is so popular, with close to 100% of teachers supporting it. “*Since my employment in 1968 I have never been given a bonus nor thank you from the Government but [KiuFunza] has made it*” (Teacher Stela, Mtwara region).

Although reaching universal FLN is the single most widely supported goal in global education, learning poverty in Africa continued to rise during the COVID pandemic. It is clear that innovative approaches are required to reverse this trend and bring about the rapid improvements in education needed – and promised by Sustainable Development Goal 4 in the 2030 United Nations Global Compact.

Piloting a new approach. Ten years ago, KiuFunza started piloting and testing the idea of offering performance-linked financial incentives to teachers in grades 1, 2, and 3 as a way to improve FLN in Tanzania. Since then, we have paid about 7,000 performance bonuses worth close to one million USD to teachers in rural and urban public primary schools, in 19 of the 26 administrative regions in mainland Tanzania. These incentives supported foundational learning in more than 300,000 student-years (a student could benefit during more than one year).

How KiuFunza works. By rewarding teachers for each individual student who masters skills, large classes become an opportunity rather than just a problem for teachers. We call the incentive system Pay-by-Skill, and we provide a small cash incentive of on average 0.75 USD for each skill that a student passes in the two focal subjects: these are reading Kiswahili (with skills such as reading words, sentences, or a short story) and numeracy (with skills including counting, addition, subtraction). Harder skills carry somewhat larger payments than easier skills. The more skills a student masters, the higher the payout to his/her teacher. The skill payments add up to an average performance bonus of 128 USD per teacher per year (or around 3.5 percent of the annual teacher's salary).

Results for primary grade learners. KiuFunza has been the subject of three randomized evaluations in Tanzania, implemented by academic researchers affiliated with the Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL). These nationally representative impact evaluations show that all phases of KiuFunza improved student learning. FLN mastery improved across all subjects and skills, for all types of students (girls and boys, low and high performing). Our most recent randomized trial finds that in the third year of implementation, in comparison with the control group, student learning improved by an average of 0.34 Standard Deviations (SD). To put this in context: the median learning impact in a recent literature review is 0.10.

We now have a decade's worth of evidence showing that modestly sized cash incentives to teachers substantially improve FLN results. They also show that KiuFunza incentives can boost the learning effects of other education investments and programs, such as teacher training. Moreover, results show that learning among students in treatment schools improved *as if they had received an additional 3 to 4 months' worth of business-as-usual instruction per year*.

Cost-effectiveness. A recent impact evaluation shows that KiuFunza is *one of the most cost-effective programs in the world*. KiuFunza has a learning impact that is in the top 25-10 percent of the recent literature, while our simple intervention has a per student cost of about 7 USD, one of the lowest unit costs reported in the learning literature. Taken together, KiuFunza has a cost-effectiveness of 4.79 SD improvement in learning per 100 USD spent, well above the cost-effectiveness metrics for other education interventions.

Next: getting to scale. KiuFunza is now eminently scalable owing to both the program's simplicity and the substantial implementation capacity we have developed. KiuFunza has a cost-effective design that is currently offered in 265 schools in Tanzania. Our short-term goal is to grow KiuFunza implementation to cover 2,000 low performing schools – over 10% of all government schools in Tanzania, for the 2026-2030 period. Such an operation would provide performance incentives to about 10,000 teachers and improve foundational learning for some 600,000 students per year. Our final goal is for the government, education stakeholders and donors in Tanzania (and possibly elsewhere in Africa) to endorse the idea and have it

implemented to boost FLN at scale. Size matters and to reach this goal, KiuFunza need to become more visible.

At 2,000 schools, KiuFunza would represent a meaningful private boost to teacher effort and student outcomes in the weakest primary schools in the Tanzanian public system. It would also increase the visibility of our innovation, its feasibility and excellent value-for-money proposition, domestically and internationally. This visibility is important in our theory of scale, as it provides political attention in a transactional system that prioritizes ideas attached to sizable financial resources.

Why now? KiuFunza's positive impact on teacher agency comes at an opportune time. First, the post-pandemic need for improving educational outcomes is urgent, especially in view of the global SDG ambitions. Second, over the last decade a global consensus on the importance of foundational literacy and numeracy has emerged; accompanied by (a) a recognition that interventions need to be evidence-based and (b) a growing body of research on the effectiveness of alternative interventions. Third, researchers, policy makers, and funders have realized the central importance of teachers as focal agents in delivering quality education; and agree that both skills and motivation are key. Fourth, paying for outcomes in international and local development initiatives has been shown to deliver focus and results.

KiuFunza is in sync with all these trends and can capitalize on ten years' worth of evidence and experience to make a credible positive impact on foundational learning. KiuFunza has proof of concept in Tanzania but needs support to show that our solution will also work at larger scale, including in similar settings in other countries.

KiuFunza's selling points in summary:

1. It is popular: the program has huge teacher approval, and is endorsed by education administrators and local government officials.
2. It is a light-touch, simple, and low-cost intervention.
3. It keeps teachers in the classroom – lessening the need for teacher supervision by providing a structure that rewards self-regulation and self-improvement.
4. It puts very few demands on teachers, essentially asking them to do their job better.
5. It is non-punitive, since there is only a material upside for the teachers.
6. It improves ownership – teachers are motivated to innovate, trying new ways of teaching and improving outcomes.
7. It targets teachers in the most challenging grades, essential for foundational learning.
8. It ensures that all students gain: low-, middle and high-performing. And there are no adverse effects on results in non-incentivized grades and subjects.
9. It is radically innovative in its focus on learning outcomes in the early grades. Most learning interventions focus on inputs, learning materials and teacher capacity building, with mixed results. Very few interventions have our laser focus on learning outcome incentives, and few have the ambition to provide incentives at scale.

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